

Formation Engine Methodology

Theory Layer — Energy Decomposition,
Pairwise Interaction Structure,
Interaction Graph, and Material Kernel

VSEPR-SIM Project

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Abstract

This document establishes the formal theoretical infrastructure for the VSEPR-SIM coarse-grained simulation platform. Four interconnected formalisms are developed:

1. **Full Energy Decomposition** (§??): the nine-channel decomposition of the total potential energy U_{tot} into physically interpretable, individually inspectable terms.
2. **Pairwise Mixed Interaction Structure** (§??): the per-pair, per-species decomposition U_{ij}^{xy} for mixed bead types $x, y \in \{a, b\}$.
3. **Interaction Graph** (§??): the graph $G = (V, E)$ encoding the combinatorial backbone of the bead system, with adjacency, degree, and Laplacian analysis.
4. **Material Kernel Vector** (§??): the five-component per-bead state vector $\mathbf{M}_k = [\phi_k, \psi_k, \chi_k, \omega_k, E_k]^\top$ that encodes the essential material identity of each bead or domain.

These formalisms are deterministic, explicitly inspectable, and free of stochastic methods. No density-functional theory (DFT) or Monte Carlo sampling is employed. All quantities are computed analytically from the coarse-grained bead state, environment observables, and registry data.

Design principle: Every mapping decision, every metric, every intermediate result must be explicitly inspectable, traceable, and deterministic. No hidden state.

Contents

§1 Full Energy Decomposition

1.1 Total Energy of the System

The total potential energy of the coarse-grained bead system is written as the sum of nine physically distinct channels:

$$U_{\text{tot}} = U_{\text{bond}} + U_{\text{angle}} + U_{\text{tors}} + U_{\text{vdW}} + U_{\text{Coul}} + U_{\text{pol}} + U_{\text{decay}} + U_{\text{resp}} + U_{\text{ext}} \quad (1)$$

Each term has a precise physical origin and a well-defined mapping to the implementation.

1.2 Channel Definitions

1.2.1 Bonded Terms: U_{bond} , U_{angle} , U_{tors}

At the atomistic level, these terms capture covalent bond stretching, angle bending, and torsional rotation:

$$U_{\text{bond}} = \sum_{(i,j) \in \mathbf{B}} \frac{1}{2} k_b (r_{ij} - r_0)^2 \quad (2)$$

$$U_{\text{angle}} = \sum_{\text{angles}} \frac{1}{2} k_\theta (\theta_{ijk} - \theta_0)^2 \quad (3)$$

$$U_{\text{tors}} = \sum_{\text{dihedrals}} V_n [1 + \cos(n\phi_{ijkl} - \gamma)] \quad (4)$$

CG absorption. At the coarse-grained Level 2 resolution, direct bond, angle, and torsion terms are *absorbed* into the spherical-harmonic (SH) orientation channels and the steric kernel. The CG mapping `map_reaction_to_beads()` distributes intramolecular structure into the bead descriptor coefficients $\{c_{\ell m}^{(k)}\}$. Consequently, U_{bond} , U_{angle} , and U_{tors} appear explicitly only at the atomistic level; their CG image is spread across the remaining six channels.

1.2.2 Van der Waals: U_{vdW}

The isotropic Lennard-Jones 12-6 potential plus the dispersion modulation channel [B9]:

$$U_{\text{vdW}} = \sum_{i < j} 4\varepsilon_{ij} \left[\left(\frac{\sigma_{ij}}{r_{ij}} \right)^{12} - \left(\frac{\sigma_{ij}}{r_{ij}} \right)^6 \right] \cdot g_d(\bar{\eta}_{ij}) \quad (5)$$

where $g_d(\bar{\eta}) = 1 + \gamma_d \cdot \bar{\eta}$ is the dispersion modulation factor and $\bar{\eta}_{ij} = \frac{1}{2}(\eta_i + \eta_j)$ is the mean slow state of the pair.

1.2.3 Electrostatic: U_{Coul}

The Coulombic interaction with environment-responsive screening [B8]:

$$U_{\text{Coul}} = \sum_{i < j} k_e \frac{q_i q_j}{r_{ij}} \cdot g_e(\bar{\eta}_{ij}) \quad (6)$$

where $g_e(\bar{\eta}) = 1 + \gamma_e \cdot \bar{\eta}$ and $\gamma_e < 0$ implements electrostatic screening in dense environments.

1.2.4 Polarisation: U_{pol}

The induced-dipole energy from the QM Level-0 polarisability proxy:

$$U_{\text{pol}} = -\frac{1}{2} \sum_i \alpha_i |\mathbf{E}_i^{\text{local}}|^2 \quad (7)$$

where α_i is the polarisability proxy (in $\text{\AA}^3$) from `QMDescriptor`, and $\mathbf{E}_i^{\text{local}}$ is the local electric field at bead i from all neighbours.

1.2.5 Decay Dissipation: U_{decay}

Energy stored in the slow-state relaxation dynamics that has not yet dissipated to steady state:

$$U_{\text{decay}} = -\frac{1}{\tau} \sum_i (f_i - \eta_i)^2 \quad (8)$$

where f_i is the target function $f(\hat{\rho}_i, \hat{P}_{2,i})$ and η_i is the current slow state. This term vanishes at convergence ($f_i = \eta_i$ for all i).

An additional pairwise decay-coupled term captures interfacial dissipation from η -mismatch between neighbouring beads:

$$U_{\text{decay}}^{\text{coupled}} = -\gamma_d \sum_{i < j} |\Delta\eta_{ij}| \cdot S_{\text{sw}}(r_{ij}; r_c, \delta) \quad (9)$$

where S_{sw} is the smooth switching function and $\Delta\eta_{ij} = \eta_i - \eta_j$. Pairs with mismatched η (one ordered, one disordered) experience a dissipative coupling that drives them toward compatible states — the CG equivalent of interfacial energy at domain boundaries.

1.2.6 Environment-Responsive Coupling: U_{resp}

The excess energy arising from environment modulation — the difference between the modulated and unmodulated interaction:

$$U_{\text{resp}} = \sum_{i < j} \sum_k (g_k(\bar{\eta}_{ij}) - 1) \cdot U_{ij,k}^{\text{bare}} = \sum_{i < j} \sum_k \gamma_k \bar{\eta}_{ij} \cdot U_{ij,k}^{\text{bare}} \quad (10)$$

where the sum over k runs over channels {steric, elec, disp} and $U_{ij,k}^{\text{bare}}$ is the unmodulated base interaction.

1.2.7 External Field: U_{ext}

Coupling to an externally imposed field (electric, magnetic, gravitational, or confinement potential):

$$U_{\text{ext}} = \sum_i V_{\text{ext}}(\mathbf{R}_i) \quad (11)$$

This channel is a placeholder for future extensions. Currently $U_{\text{ext}} = 0$ in all simulations.

1.3 Energy Decomposition Diagnostic

The `EnergyDecomposition` struct provides per-channel access to all terms at every step. The total is reconstructed additively:

$$U_{\text{tot}} = \sum_{k=0}^7 U_k \quad (12)$$

where each U_k is tagged with an `EnergyChannel` enum. Implementation: `coarse_grain/theory/energy_c`

1.4 Mapping to Implementation

Channel	Tag	6+9 Unit	Source
U_{vdW}	VdW	S4, B9	LJ 12-6 + g_d
U_{Coul}	Coulomb	S4, B8	Coulomb + g_e
U_{steric}	Steric	S4, B7	SH steric kernel + g_s
U_{orient}	Orient	B4	SH overlap integral
U_{pol}	Pol	QM L0	$-\frac{1}{2}\alpha \mathbf{E} ^2$
U_{decay}	Decay	B6	η -relaxation + coupled
U_{resp}	Resp	B7–B9	$(g_k - 1) \cdot U^{\text{bare}}$
U_{ext}	External	—	Future placeholder

§2 Pairwise Mixed Interaction Structure

2.1 Per-Pair Decomposition

Each pairwise interaction between beads i and j of species $x, y \in \{a, b\}$ is decomposed into five terms:

$$U_{ij}^{xy} = U_{ij,\text{steric}}^{xy} + U_{ij,\text{elec}}^{xy} + U_{ij,\text{disp}}^{xy} + U_{ij,\text{orient}}^{xy} + U_{ij,\text{decay-coupled}}^{xy} \quad x, y \in \{a, b\} \quad (13)$$

2.2 Channel Formulas

2.2.1 Steric Channel

The steric interaction is the SH-expanded overlap with environment-modulated kernel:

$$U_{ij,\text{steric}}^{xy} = \sum_{\ell=0}^{\ell_{\max}} K_s(\ell, r_{ij}) \cdot g_s(\bar{\eta}_{ij}) \cdot \sum_{m=-\ell}^{\ell} c_{\ell m}^{(s,x,i)} \tilde{c}_{\ell m}^{(s,y,j)} \quad (14)$$

where $\tilde{c}$ denotes coefficients of bead j rotated into the frame of bead i via the Wigner D-matrix, and $g_s = 1 + \gamma_s \cdot \bar{\eta}_{ij}$ is the steric modulation factor.

2.2.2 Electrostatic Channel

$$U_{ij,\text{elec}}^{xy} = \sum_{\ell=0}^{\ell_{\max}} K_e(\ell, r_{ij}) \cdot g_e(\bar{\eta}_{ij}) \cdot \sum_{m=-\ell}^{\ell} c_{\ell m}^{(e,x,i)} \tilde{c}_{\ell m}^{(e,y,j)} \quad (15)$$

The electrostatic kernel $K_e(\ell, r)$ decays as $r^{-(2\ell+1)}$ for the multipole expansion and as r^{-1} for the monopole. The modulation $g_e < 1$ in dense environments (screening).

2.2.3 Dispersion Channel

$$U_{ij,\text{disp}}^{xy} = \sum_{\ell=0}^{\ell_{\max}} K_d(\ell, r_{ij}) \cdot g_d(\bar{\eta}_{ij}) \cdot \sum_{m=-\ell}^{\ell} c_{\ell m}^{(d,x,i)} \tilde{c}_{\ell m}^{(d,y,j)} \quad (16)$$

The dispersion kernel $K_d(\ell, r)$ has r^{-6} leading order. Enhancement under ordering: $g_d > 1$ when $\bar{\eta} > 0$.

2.2.4 Orientational Channel

$$U_{ij,\text{orient}}^{xy} = \lambda_{\text{orient}} \cdot \sum_{k \in \{s,e,d\}} \sum_{\ell,m} c_{\ell m}^{(k,x,i)} \tilde{c}_{\ell m}^{(k,y,j)} \cdot w_{\ell}(r_{ij}) \quad (17)$$

This is the pure orientational overlap contribution, summing the SH dot products across all channels with distance-dependent weights $w_{\ell}(r) = S_{\text{sw}}(r; r_c, \delta)$.

2.2.5 Decay-Coupled Channel

$$U_{ij,\text{decay-coupled}}^{xy} = -\gamma_d \cdot |\eta_i - \eta_j| \cdot S_{\text{sw}}(r_{ij}; r_c, \delta) \quad (18)$$

This captures the dissipative penalty for η -mismatch across an interface, driving neighbouring beads toward coherent internal states.

2.3 Species Mixing Rules

For pairs of different species $x \neq y$, the interaction parameters follow the standard combining rules:

$$\sigma_{xy} = \frac{1}{2}(\sigma_x + \sigma_y) \quad (\text{Lorentz rule}) \quad (19)$$

$$\varepsilon_{xy} = \sqrt{\varepsilon_x \cdot \varepsilon_y} \quad (\text{Berthelot rule}) \quad (20)$$

For metallic systems, the alloy proxy uses Vegard's law:

$$X_{\text{alloy}} = (1 - x_B) X_A + x_B X_B \quad (21)$$

for properties $X \in \{a_0, M, E_{\text{coh}}, \text{CN}_{\text{bulk}}\}$.

2.4 Modulation Invariant

The modulation factor must preserve the sign of the base kernel:

$$|1 + \gamma_k \cdot \bar{\eta}| > 0 \quad \forall k \in \{s, e, d\}, \quad \bar{\eta} \in [0, 1] \quad (22)$$

This is enforced numerically with a floor of 10^{-10} .

2.5 Diagnostic Record

The `PairInteraction` struct carries all five energy terms, the three modulation factors g_s, g_e, g_d , the mean $\bar{\eta}$, the separation r_{ij} , and the species tags x, y . Every pairwise interaction is individually inspectable.

Implementation: `coarse_grain/theory/energy_decomposition.hpp`.

§3 Interaction Graph

3.1 Graph Definition

The bead system defines an undirected interaction graph:

$$\boxed{G = (V, E), \quad |V| = N} \quad (23)$$

where $V = \{1, 2, \dots, N\}$ is the vertex set (one vertex per bead) and $E \subseteq \binom{V}{2}$ is the edge set, determined by spatial proximity.

3.2 Adjacency

The adjacency matrix $\mathbf{A} \in \{0, 1\}^{N \times N}$ is defined by:

$$A_{ij} = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } (i, j) \in E \\ 0 & \text{if } (i, j) \notin E \end{cases} \quad (24)$$

An edge exists between beads i and j if and only if they are within the interaction cutoff:

$$(i, j) \in E \iff |\mathbf{R}_i - \mathbf{R}_j| < r_{\text{cut}} \quad (25)$$

For weighted graphs, A_{ij} is replaced by the switching function:

$$A_{ij}^{(w)} = S_{\text{sw}}(r_{ij}; r_c, \delta) \quad (26)$$

3.3 Degree

The degree of vertex i is the number of edges incident to it:

$$\deg(i) = \sum_{j=1}^N A_{ij} \quad (27)$$

This maps directly to the coordination number C_i from the environment-responsive bead state:

$$C_i \equiv \deg(i) \quad (28)$$

3.4 Degree Matrix and Graph Laplacian

The degree matrix is the diagonal matrix of degrees:

$$\mathbf{D} = \text{diag}(\deg(1), \deg(2), \dots, \deg(N)) \quad (29)$$

The combinatorial graph Laplacian is:

$$\boxed{\mathbf{L} = \mathbf{D} - \mathbf{A}} \quad (30)$$

with entries:

$$L_{ij} = \begin{cases} \deg(i) & \text{if } i = j \\ -A_{ij} & \text{if } i \neq j \end{cases} \quad (31)$$

3.5 Spectral Properties

The eigenvalues $\lambda_1 \leq \lambda_2 \leq \dots \leq \lambda_N$ of $\mathbf{L}$ characterise the connectivity of the graph:

- $\lambda_1 = 0$ always (eigenvector $\mathbf{1}$, the constant vector).
- The multiplicity of $\lambda = 0$ equals the number of connected components.
- $\lambda_2 > 0$ if and only if G is connected. λ_2 is the **algebraic connectivity** (Fiedler value).
- $\text{tr}(\mathbf{L}) = \sum_i \deg(i) = 2|E|$.

For the interaction graph, the Fiedler value measures how strongly the bead system is connected. A small λ_2 indicates a system close to fragmentation (near-critical domain boundary).

3.6 Graph Diagnostics

The `GraphDiagnostics` struct provides:

Quantity	Formula	Physical meaning
$ V $	N	Bead count
$ E $	edge count	Interaction pair count
$\langle k \rangle$	$2 E /N$	Mean coordination
$\max(k)$	$\max_i \deg(i)$	Most connected bead
$\text{Var}(k)$	sample variance of degrees	Structural heterogeneity
$\langle r \rangle$	mean r_{ij} over E	Mean interaction distance
$r_{\min}$	$\min r_{ij}$	Closest pair
$r_{\max}$	$\max r_{ij}$	Edge at cutoff boundary

Implementation: `coarse_grain/theory/graph_topology.hpp`.

§4 Material Kernel Vector

4.1 Definition

The material kernel vector $\mathbf{M}_k$ is the five-component per-bead (or per-domain) representation that encodes the essential material identity:

$$\mathbf{M}_k = \begin{pmatrix} \phi_k \\ \psi_k \\ \chi_k \\ \omega_k \\ E_k \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{R}^5 \quad (32)$$

4.2 Component Definitions

4.2.1 Electrostatic Potential ϕ_k

The electrostatic potential at the bead centre, from the Coulombic field of all neighbours modulated by the environment coupling:

$$\phi_k = \sum_{j \neq k} k_e \frac{q_j \cdot g_e(\bar{\eta}_{kj})}{r_{kj}} \quad [\text{kcal/mol/e}] \quad (33)$$

Source: `QMDescriptor::phi_elec` or, in the metal-registry fallback, the work function φ of the element.

4.2.2 Structural Coherence ψ_k

The slow-state variable encoding the degree of structural order attained by the bead through relaxation dynamics:

$$\psi_k = \eta_k \in [0, 1] \quad (34)$$

where η_k is governed by the first-order relaxation equation:

$$\frac{d\eta_k}{dt} = \frac{f_k - \eta_k}{\tau} \quad (35)$$

At convergence, $\psi_k \rightarrow f_k = \alpha \hat{\rho}_k + \beta \hat{P}_{2,k}$.

4.2.3 Electronegativity χ_k

The electronegativity of the bead on the Pauling scale, encoding chemical identity and electron-drawing power:

$$\chi_k = \bar{\chi}_{\text{atoms}} = \frac{1}{N_{\text{atoms}}} \sum_{a \in \text{bead } k} \chi_a^{\text{Pauling}} \quad (36)$$

Source: `QMDescriptor::chi_mean` or `MetalRecord::electronegativity_pauling`.

4.2.4 Orbital Overlap ω_k

The orbital overlap proxy, measuring the degree of covalent bonding character in the bead's local neighbourhood:

$$\omega_k = \frac{1}{N_{\text{nbr}}} \sum_{j \in \text{nbr}(k)} \exp\left(-\frac{r_{kj}}{r_{\text{overlap}}}\right) \cdot \frac{\chi_k \cdot \chi_j}{\chi_k + \chi_j} \in [0, 1] \quad (37)$$

where $r_{\text{overlap}} = \frac{1}{2}(\sigma_k + \sigma_j)$ is the mean LJ radius. Source: `QMDescriptor::omega_overlap`.

4.2.5 Local Energy Density E_k

The per-bead share of the total potential energy:

$$E_k = \frac{U_{\text{tot}}}{N} \quad [\text{kcal/mol}] \quad (38)$$

This is the mean-field approximation. A pair-resolved variant assigns:

$$E_k^{\text{pair}} = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{j \neq k} U_{kj}^{\text{tot}} \quad (39)$$

4.3 Properties of $\mathbf{M}_k$

1. **Deterministic:** computed entirely from CG state + registry data. No stochastic sampling.
2. **Low-dimensional:** 5 real-valued components — tractable for comparison, clustering, and visualisation.
3. **Rotationally invariant:** all components are scalars; $\mathbf{M}_k$ is independent of the global coordinate frame.
4. **Basis for comparison:** the Euclidean distance $\|\mathbf{M}_a - \mathbf{M}_b\|_2$ measures material dissimilarity between two beads or domains.
5. **Basis for classification:** clustering in $\mathbb{R}^5$ identifies material families.

4.4 Distance and Similarity

The Euclidean distance between two kernels is:

$$d(\mathbf{M}_a, \mathbf{M}_b) = \left[(\phi_a - \phi_b)^2 + (\psi_a - \psi_b)^2 + (\chi_a - \chi_b)^2 + (\omega_a - \omega_b)^2 + (E_a - E_b)^2 \right]^{1/2} \quad (40)$$

The cosine similarity is:

$$\cos \theta = \frac{\mathbf{M}_a \cdot \mathbf{M}_b}{\|\mathbf{M}_a\| \cdot \|\mathbf{M}_b\|} \quad (41)$$

The `MaterialDistance` struct provides both measures plus per-component differences for diagnostic inspection.

4.5 Domain Aggregation

For a Level 3 domain containing n member beads, the aggregate kernel is the arithmetic mean:

$$\mathbf{M}_{\text{domain}} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n \mathbf{M}_k \quad (42)$$

This is the kernel vector that flows from L3 to the macro-DM layer.

4.6 Kernel Spectrum

The system-wide distribution of kernels is characterised by:

$$\langle \mathbf{M} \rangle = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{k=1}^N \mathbf{M}_k \quad (\text{component-wise mean}) \quad (43)$$

$$\text{Var}(\mathbf{M}) = \frac{1}{N-1} \sum_{k=1}^N (\mathbf{M}_k - \langle \mathbf{M} \rangle) \odot (\mathbf{M}_k - \langle \mathbf{M} \rangle) \quad (\text{component-wise variance}) \quad (44)$$

where $\odot$ denotes the Hadamard (element-wise) product.

A low variance in all components indicates a homogeneous material; high variance in ψ (structural coherence) indicates coexisting ordered and disordered domains.

Implementation: `coarse_grain/theory/material_kernel.hpp`.

§5 Interconnection of Formalisms

The four formalisms developed in this document are not independent; they form a connected theoretical infrastructure:

Formalism	→	Consumer
$G = (V, E)$	provides	edge iteration for $\sum_{i < j}$ in §??
U_{ij}^{xy}	provides	per-pair energy for E_k in $\mathbf{M}_k$
$\deg(i)$	provides	coordination C_i for environment state
η_i	provides	ψ_k component of $\mathbf{M}_k$
$\mathbf{M}_k$	provides	input to L3 domain aggregation
$\mathbf{M}_{\text{domain}}$	provides	input to macro-DM

The data flow is:

$$\text{Atomistic} \xrightarrow{\text{CG map}} G = (V, E) \xrightarrow{\text{\S3.3 pairs}} U_{\text{tot}} \xrightarrow{\text{\S T.2}} \mathbf{M}_k \xrightarrow{\text{L3 agg}} \mathbf{M}_{\text{domain}} \xrightarrow{\text{handoff}} \text{Macro-DM} \quad (45)$$

Every intermediate is explicitly inspectable. No hidden state propagates through this pipeline.

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